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Chronicle User Guilde



Chronicle User Guide

by Petre Popescu

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Installation	1
Getting Started	2
The Studio Interface & Navigation	3
Distraction-Free Modes: Studio, Minimalist & Typewriter Zen	5
Settings, Themes & Workspace Customization	7
Visual Narrative Timeline Studio	9
Cast Presence Heatmap & Character Grid	11
Worldbuilding Codex (Characters & Locations)	12
Reading Mode, Offline Neural TTS & Book Cover Designer	13
Publication & Multi-Format Export Hub	15
Keyboard Shortcuts & Power-User Workflows	16

Installation

1. Windows PCs

Chronicle does not require installation on Windows.

2. MacOS

After downloading the `.dmg` file, open it and follow the instructions to drag the Chronicle icon to the Apps folder.

After that, open a terminal and type this command:

```
xattr -cr /Applications/Chronicle.app
```

Getting Started

100% Local-First Architecture

- Zero Telemetry: Chronicle collects no metrics, has no trackers, and maintains no remote database.
- 100% GenAI-Free: No LLMs. No text generation. Built exclusively for human writers.
- No Cloud Lock-in: Your work is saved in the open `.chronicle`` format (a standard ZIP archive containing plain JSON and raw XHTML).
- Optional Private Sync: Sync directly to your own self-hosted WebDAV server (Nextcloud, ownCloud, Fastmail) with end-to-end credential storage.

Creating or Loading Manuscripts

1. Starting with the Sample Manuscript:

When launching Chronicle, click **"Open Sample Project"** on the welcome dialog to load a complete pre-configured edition of *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, populated with chapters, character profiles, narrative timeline beats, and cast heatmaps.

2. New Blank Book:

Click "New" to initialize a clean manuscript structure with an initial chapter.

3. Importing Existing Books:

Drag and drop any standard `.epub`` or `.chronicle`` file anywhere into the studio window, or press `Ctrl+O`` to open the file browser.

The Studio Interface & Navigation

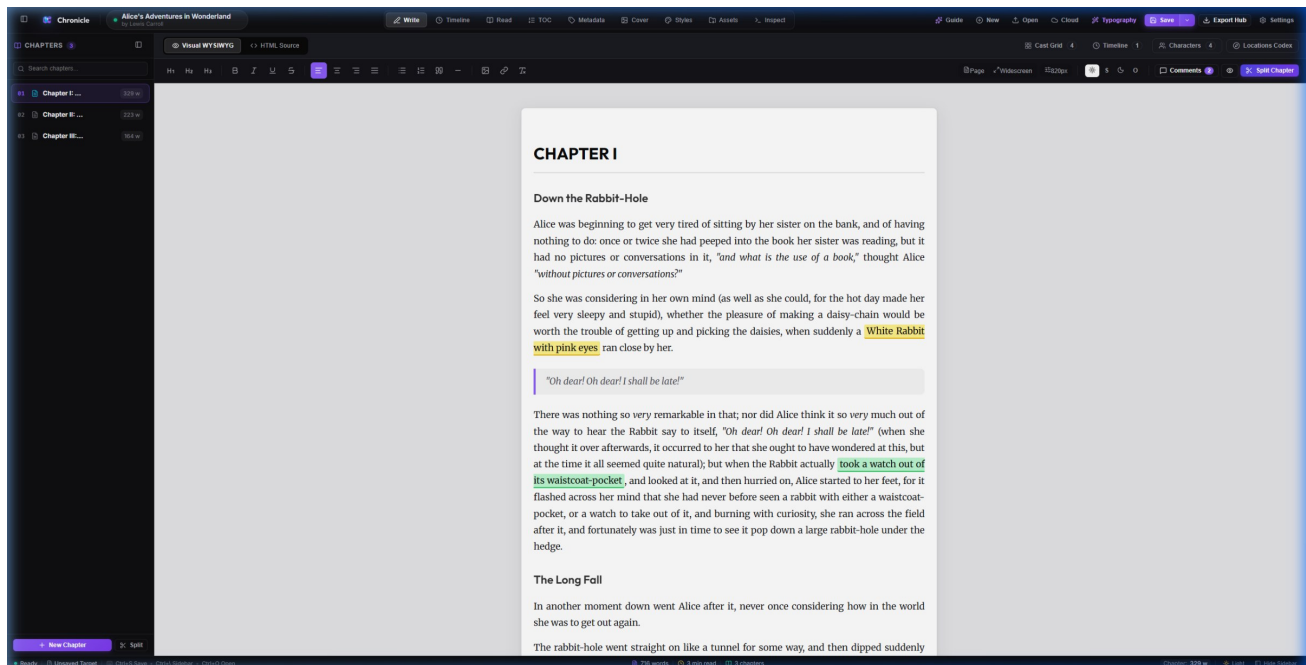


Figure 2.1: The default Studio Mode workspace featuring the Top View Switcher tabs, Chapter Binder on the left, WYSIWYG writing canvas in the center, and live session word telemetry at the bottom.

The workspace is organized into four main areas:

1. Top Navigation Bar

- Book Title & Author: Click the manuscript title to rename the project or edit book metadata (Language, Publisher, ISBN, Description).
- View Switcher Tabs: Write: Manuscript drafting with the WYSIWYG editor and chapter binder. Read: Distraction-free reader view for proofreading flow and pagination. Timeline: Multi-strand narrative timeline plotting matrix. Cast Grid: Chapter-by-chapter character presence density matrix. Codex: Worldbuilding dossiers for characters and sensory locations. Cover: Built-in graphic book cover designer. Styles: Direct CSS stylesheet editor for advanced EPUB typography. Metadata: Publication package details and Dublin Core attributes. Inspect: Raw XHTML code viewer and spine hierarchy inspector.
- Write: Manuscript drafting with the WYSIWYG editor and chapter binder.
- Read: Distraction-free reader view for proofreading flow and pagination.
- Timeline: Multi-strand narrative timeline plotting matrix.
- Cast Grid: Chapter-by-chapter character presence density matrix.
- Codex: Worldbuilding dossiers for characters and sensory locations.
- Cover: Built-in graphic book cover designer.

- **Styles:** Direct CSS stylesheet editor for advanced EPUB typography.
- **Metadata:** Publication package details and Dublin Core attributes.
- **Inspect:** Raw XHTML code viewer and spine hierarchy inspector.
- **Quick Tools:** Quick triggers for Offline Kokoro Neural Audio Proofreading, Smart Typography formatting, Export Hub, and Settings.

2. The Chapter Binder Sidebar

- **Organize Scenes:** Reorder chapters by dragging and dropping them vertically in the binder list.
- **Add Chapters:** Click the + button in the binder header to create a new scene.
- **Chapter Word Counts:** Each chapter card displays live word count statistics.
- **Quick Toggle:** Press Ctrl+\ to collapse or expand the chapter binder.

3. WYSIWYG Manuscript Canvas

- Clean, distraction-free rich-text editing with customizable margins, typography, and line spacing.
- Select any passage to attach dual-view author notes and review comments.

4. Bottom Status Bar

- Live session velocity telemetry (+X words today).
- Active chapter word count and total manuscript progress.
- Estimated reading time and selected text metrics.

Distraction-Free Modes: Studio, Minimalist & Typewriter Zen

Writing requires different mental states depending on whether you are structuring scenes, reviewing comments, or drafting prose in deep flow. Chronicle provides three calibrated focus tiers:

Minimalist Mode (Alt+M)

Conceals the chapter binder, secondary toolbars, and status bar, presenting an expansive manuscript canvas while preserving top view switching tabs.

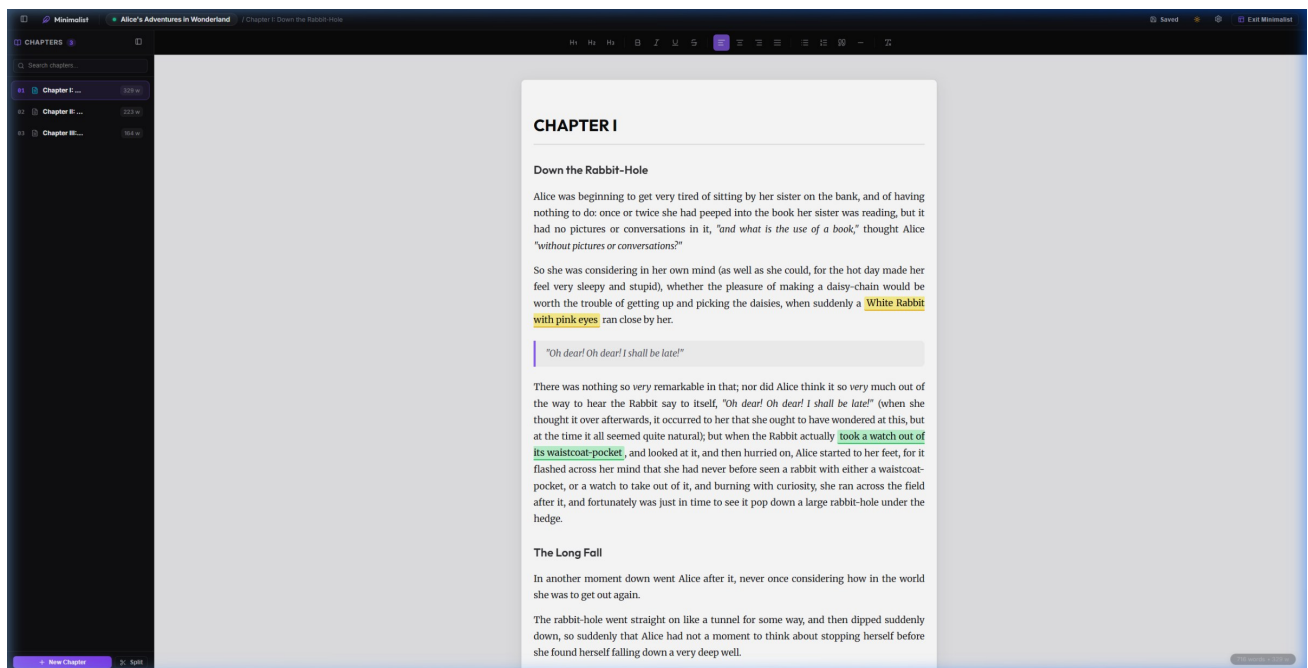


Figure 3.1: Minimalist Mode active with hidden toolbars, distraction-free canvas, and an unobtrusive Exit Minimalist button.

Typewriter Zen Mode (Alt+Z) Zen Mode is Chronicle's ultimate deep-work environment. It completely unmounts all window borders, headers, toolbars, and menus for a 100% distraction-free writing flow.

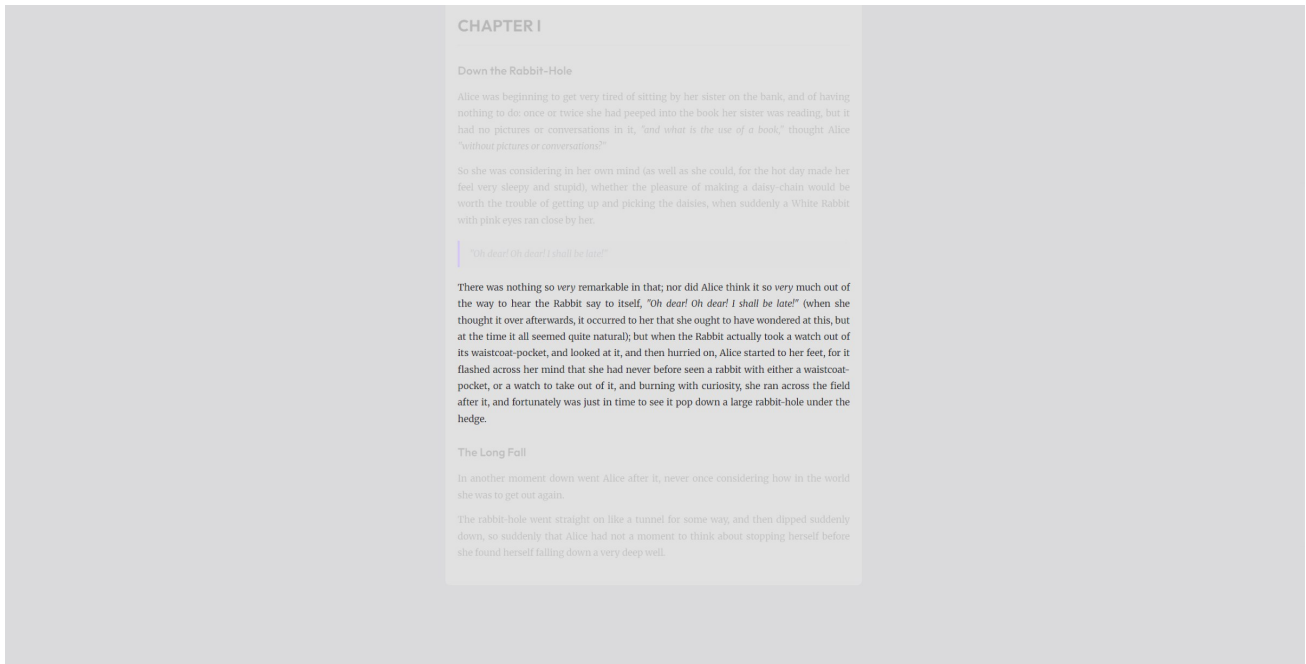


Figure 3.2: Zen Mode active. Pure zero UI while typing, centered typewriter eye-level lock, and surrounding paragraph dimming.

The 4 Core Zen Mechanics:

- **Typewriter Scrolling:** Keeps the active typing line vertically centered on screen at natural eye level. As you write, text scrolls upwards underneath your cursor, preventing neck and back strain.
- **Paragraph Focus Dimming:** Spotlights your active thought by illuminating the cursor's paragraph at 100% opacity while softly fading all surrounding paragraphs to 35% opacity.
- **The Ghost HUD (Zero UI):** Pure zero UI while writing. The moment you move your mouse, a faint, frosted-glass capsule appears showing your session word count (+X words today), active chapter, and an interactive chapter navigator to change scenes without leaving Zen mode.
- **Hide Comments & Highlights:** Conceals margin comment cards and highlighted spans so editorial review notes do not disrupt drafting momentum.

Tip: Auto-Switch on TypingIn Settings > Appearance, enable "Switch to Zen Mode on typing". Chronicle will automatically transition into Zen mode the moment you begin typing in the manuscript, and return to Studio mode when you press Esc.

Settings, Themes & Workspace Customization

Press **Ctrl+**, or click the gear icon in the header to open the expanded Settings dialog.

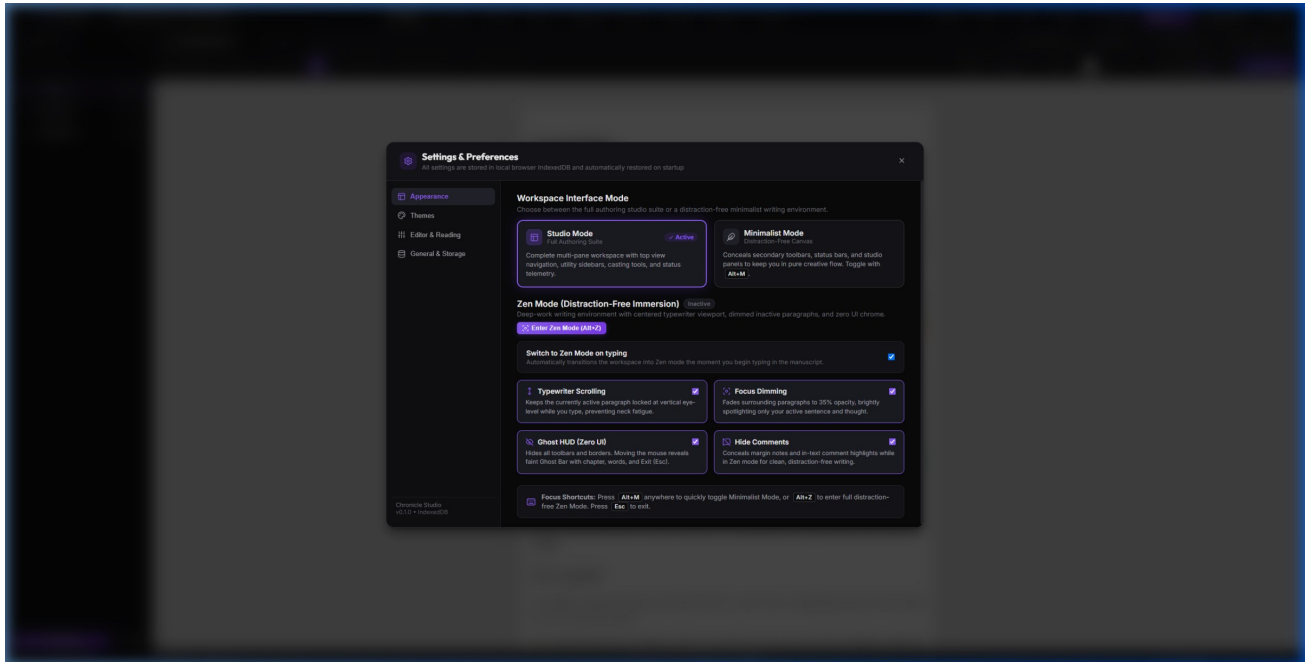


Figure 4.1: The Appearance Settings section with workspace mode options, Zen mechanics toggles, and shortcut references.

Decoupled UI Themes vs. Manuscript Canvas Paper Tones

Chronicle decouples your studio application chrome theme from your writing canvas paper tone:

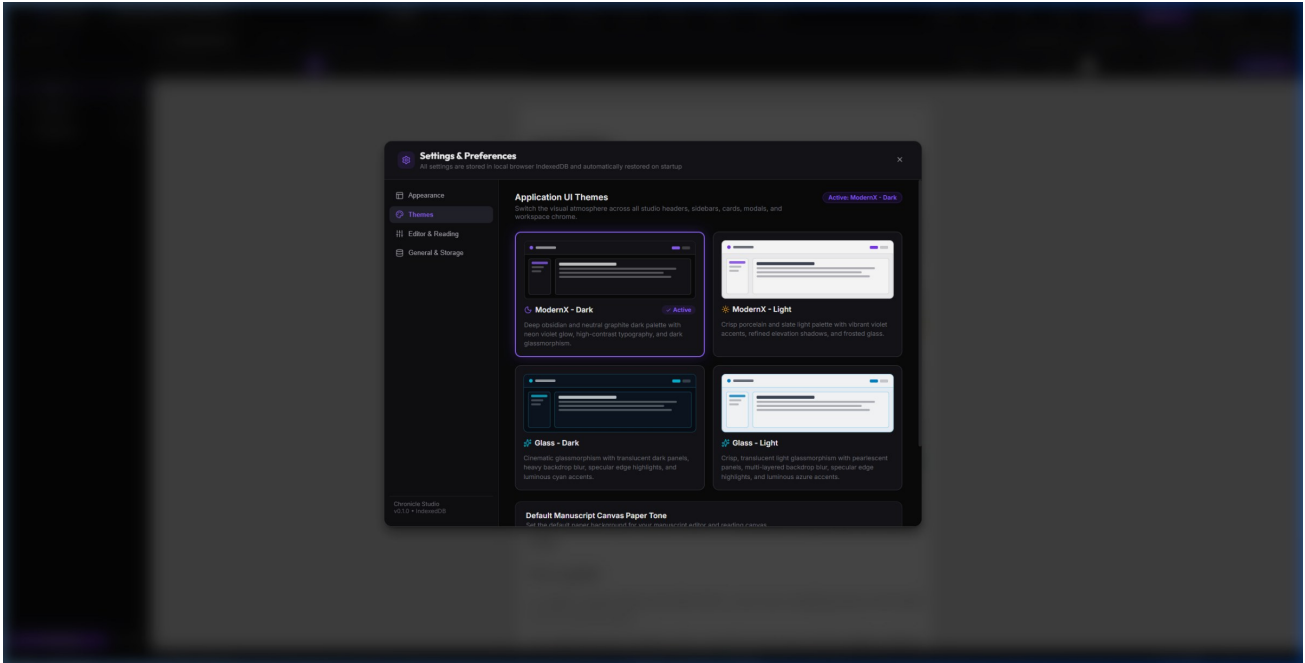


Figure 4.2: The Themes Settings section featuring live UI theme previews and manuscript paper tone presets.

- Application UI Themes: ModernX Dark: Deep obsidian graphite with violet neon accents. ModernX Light: Porcelain and slate surfaces with warm amber accents. Cyberpunk Dark: Midnight backdrop with electric cyan highlights.
- ModernX Dark: Deep obsidian graphite with violet neon accents.
- ModernX Light: Porcelain and slate surfaces with warm amber accents.
- Cyberpunk Dark: Midnight backdrop with electric cyan highlights.
- Manuscript Canvas Paper Tones: Light: Crisp warm white book paper with dark charcoal typography. Sepia: Warm antique cream paper with soft amber-sepia text. Dark: Muted charcoal backdrop with gentle off-white text. Obsidian: True pitch-black canvas with clean high-contrast lettering.
- Light: Crisp warm white book paper with dark charcoal typography.
- Sepia: Warm antique cream paper with soft amber-sepia text.
- Dark: Muted charcoal backdrop with gentle off-white text.
- Obsidian: True pitch-black canvas with clean high-contrast lettering.

Private WebDAV Cloud Storage

Configure automatic synchronization to your own self-hosted Nextcloud, ownCloud, Fastmail, or custom WebDAV server with zero monthly cloud fees and end-to-end credential privacy.

Visual Narrative Timeline Studio

Click the "Timeline" tab to open the multi-strand narrative plotting matrix.

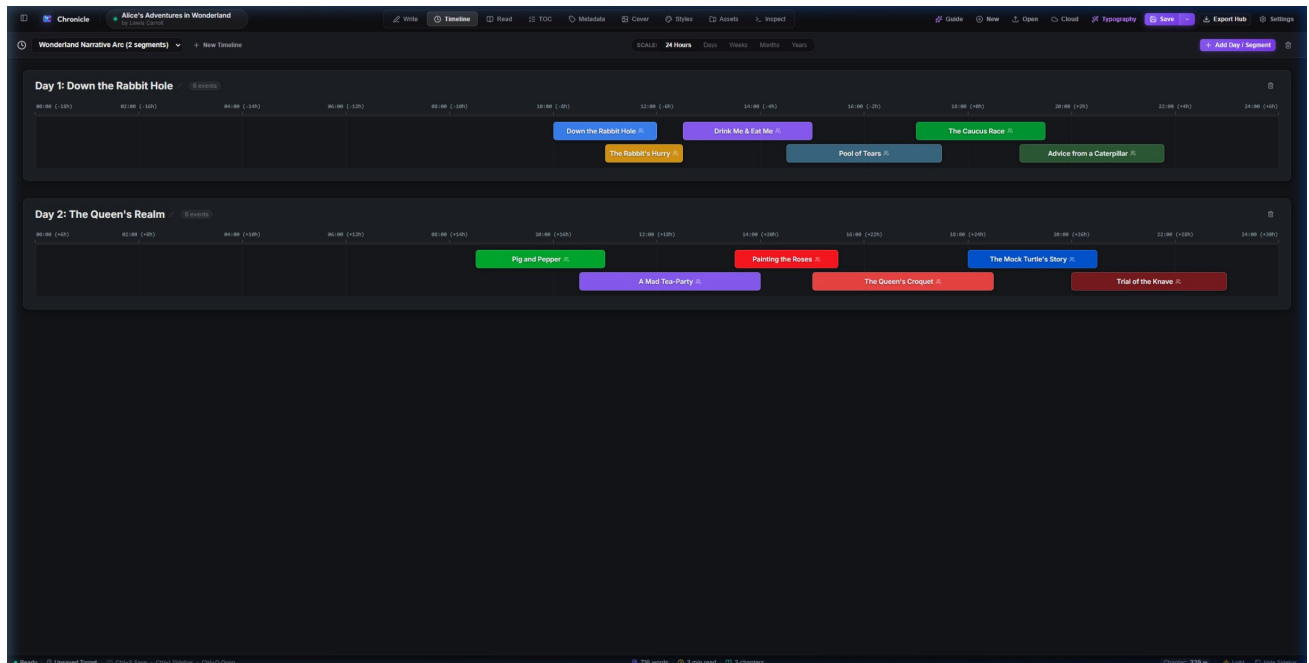


Figure 5.1: Timeline Studio displaying narrative segments (Day 1, Day 2), parallel track lanes, and character-linked event cards.

How to Create & Manage Narrative Timelines:

- Create Narrative Segments: Click "+ New Segment" to establish narrative containers (e.g., Act I: The Rabbit Hole, Day 2: The Queen's Realm). Each segment defines a temporal container with its own timescale (hours, days, months) and zero-hour calibration.
- Add Plot Events: Click "+ Add Event" to place a story beat card on the canvas. Configure start time, duration, track lane (0, 1, 2, ...), title, description, and color palette.
- Assign Participating Characters: Tag characters from your Codex who participate in the event. Character tags render with their designated theme colors directly on the timeline card.

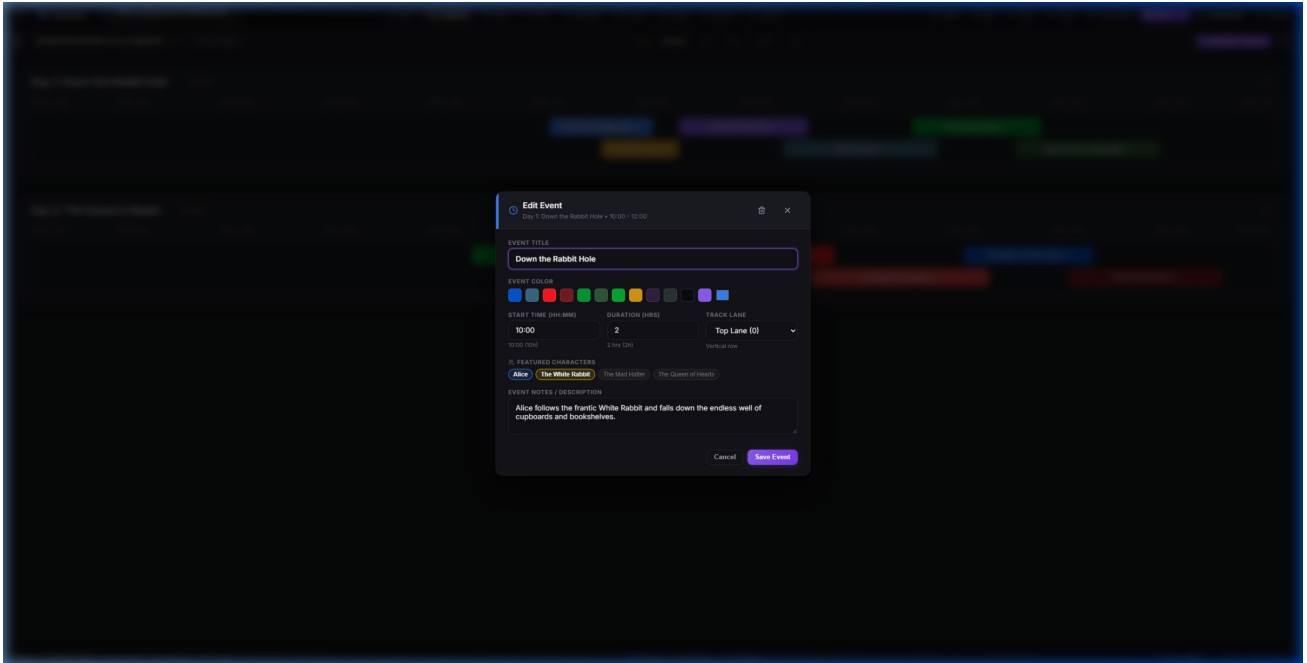


Figure 5.2: Story Event editing dialog showing title, duration, track lane assignment, narrative description, and linked characters.

Continuity & Collision Prevention: By distributing parallel plotlines across multiple horizontal lanes, Chronicle makes impossible character overlaps instantly visible—such as a character appearing in two distant places at the same time.

Cast Presence Heatmap & Character Grid

Click the "Cast Grid" tab to inspect character screen-time balance across chapters.

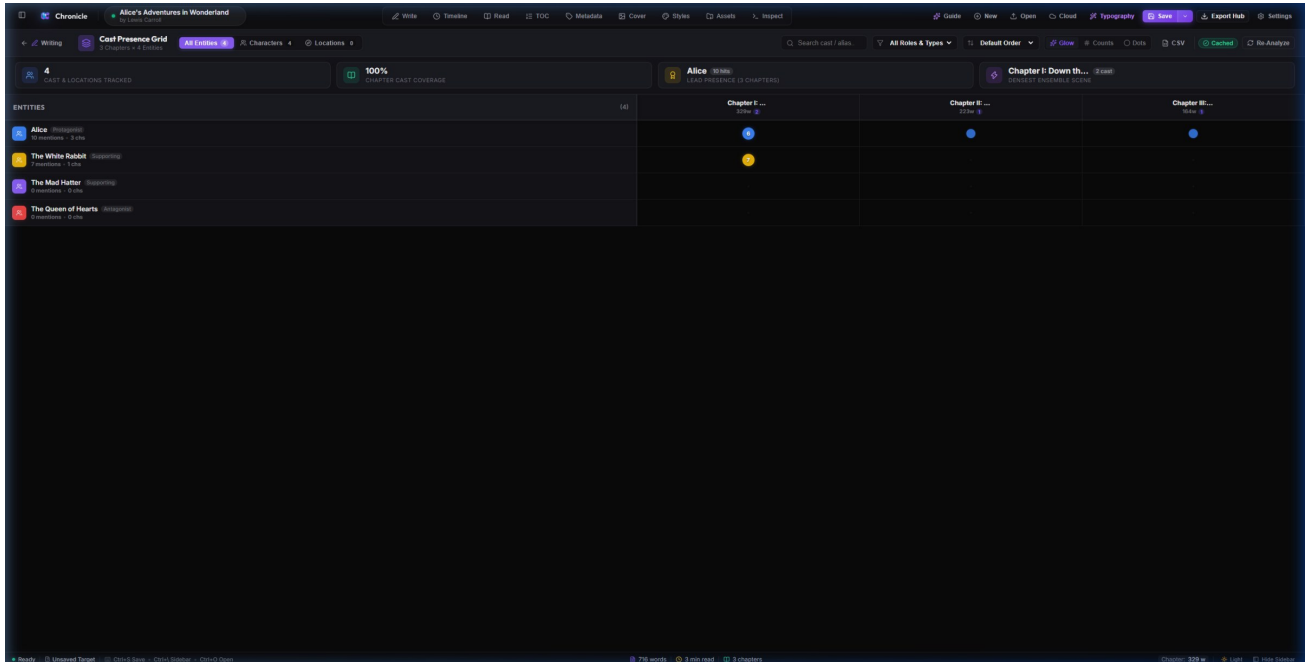


Figure 6.1: Cast Presence Grid with chapter columns along the horizontal axis, character profiles along the vertical axis, and density heat nodes.

Key Capabilities:

- **Audit Screen Time:** Circular color nodes visually demonstrate where each character appears and how frequently they speak or are mentioned.
- **Identify Missing Character Arcs:** Quickly notice if a major protagonist or villain disappears for multiple consecutive chapters.
- **Display Toggles:** Switch between Glow (vibrant heat bubbles), Counts (exact in-text mention numbers), and Dots (compact presence indicators).
- **Click-to-Inspect Dialogue:** Click any node to read dialogue excerpts and scene snippets, with a one-click button to jump straight into that chapter.
- **Export Matrix:** Click Export CSV/TSV to save the matrix to a spreadsheet for editorial analysis.

Worldbuilding Codex (Characters & Locations)

Click the "Codex" tab to manage your novel's worldbuilding bible.

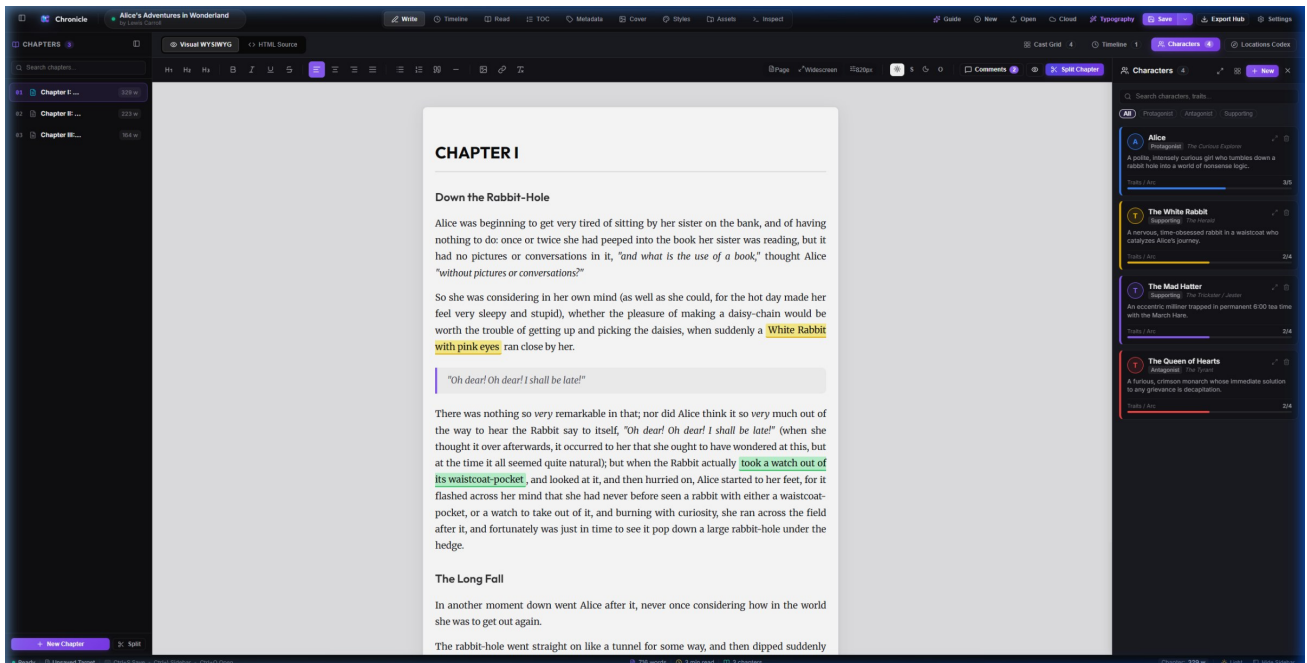


Figure 7.1: Character Codex profile drawer displaying archetype, role, physical appearance, psychological traits, and goals checklist.

- Character Profiles: Role (Protagonist, Antagonist, Supporting, Mentor). Archetype, age, occupation, and aliases. Physical appearance description and psychological motivation. Interactive Trait & Goal Checklist that tracks completed character milestones.
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- Archetype, age, occupation, and aliases.
- Physical appearance description and psychological motivation.
- Interactive Trait & Goal Checklist that tracks completed character milestones.
- Sensory Location Dossiers: Sights, sounds, smells, atmospheric weather, and temperature. Historical lore, societal significance, and environmental hazards. Interactive Landmark Checklist for tracking explored locations.
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- Historical lore, societal significance, and environmental hazards.
- Interactive Landmark Checklist for tracking explored locations.

Reading Mode, Offline Neural TTS & Book Cover Designer

1. Reader Mode (Read Tab)

Publication-accurate reading view with customizable column widths (560px to 1080px), adjustable book typefaces, and reading progress indicators.

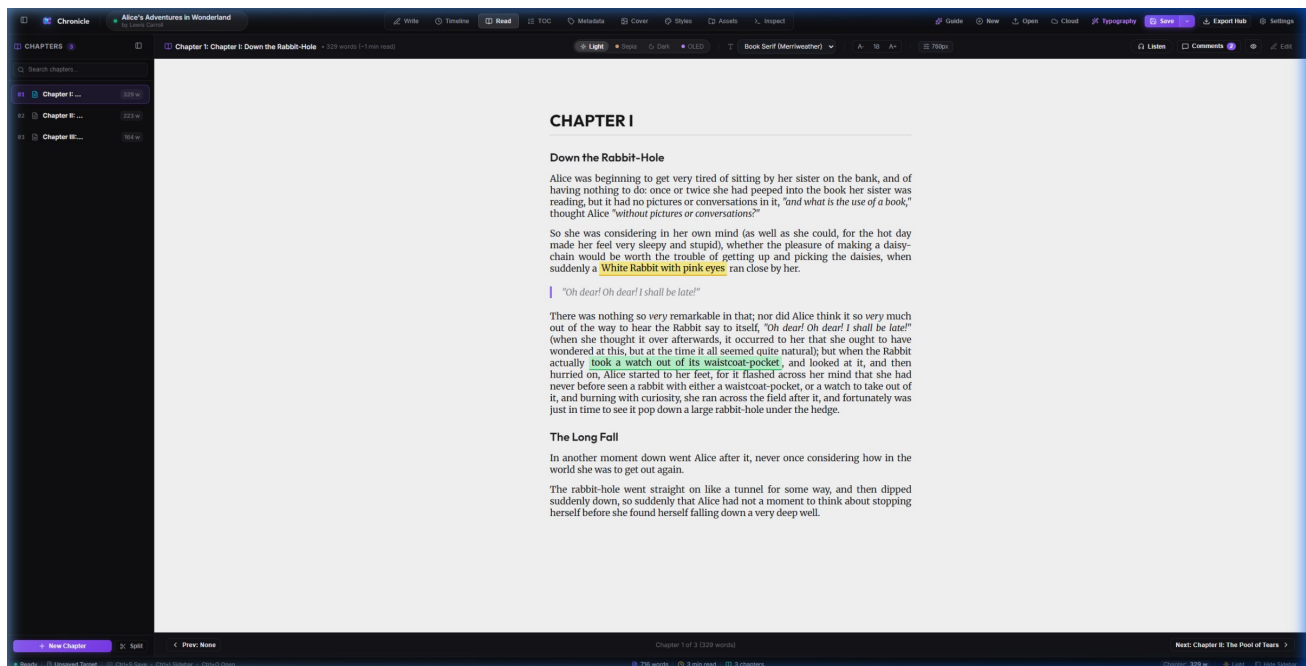


Figure 8.1: Reader Mode showing comfortable margins, warm sepia paper tone, and chapter progress indicators.

2. Offline Kokoro Neural Audio Proofreading

Catch clumsy phrasing, dialogue cadence hitches, and typos by listening to your prose read aloud by state-of-the-art Kokoro neural voice models running directly in your browser via WebGPU and WebAssembly. No text is ever transmitted over the network.

3. Built-In Graphic Book Cover Designer

Click the "Cover" tab to design publication-grade ebook covers directly inside Chronicle without external graphics tools.

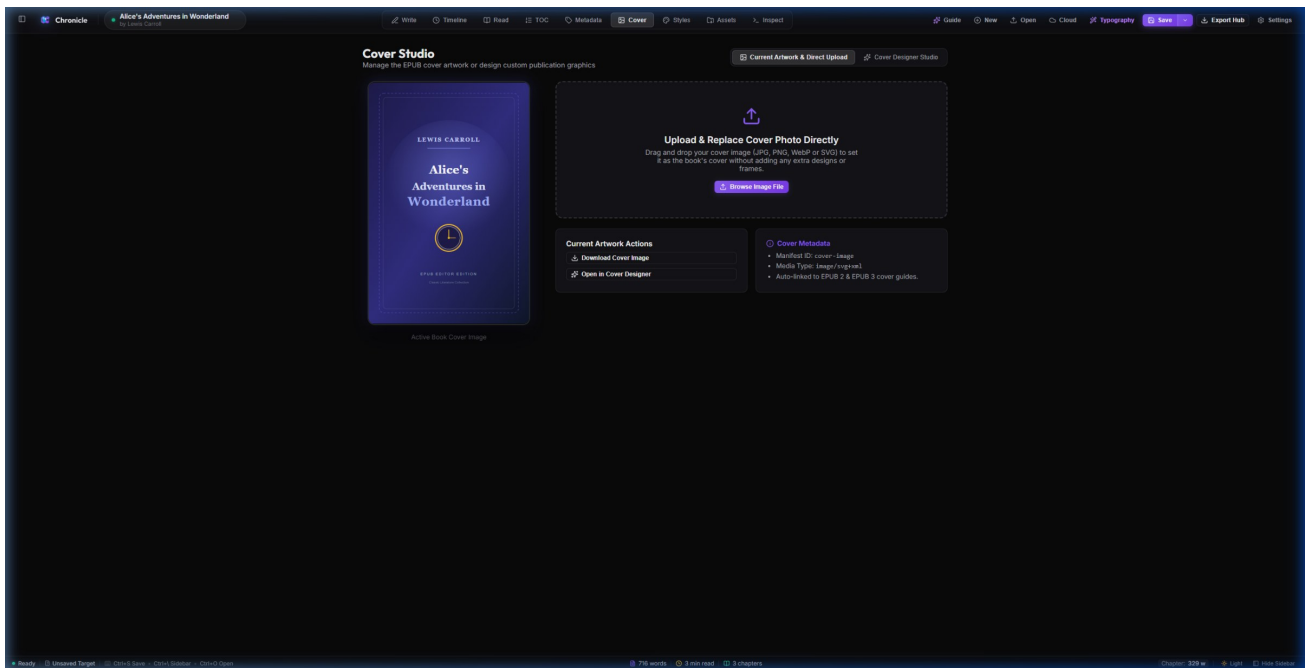


Figure 8.2: Built-in Book Cover Designer showing title typography controls, genre emblems, color palettes, and high-resolution export.

Publication & Multi-Format Export Hub

Click "Export Hub" in the header toolbar to generate bookstore-ready files:

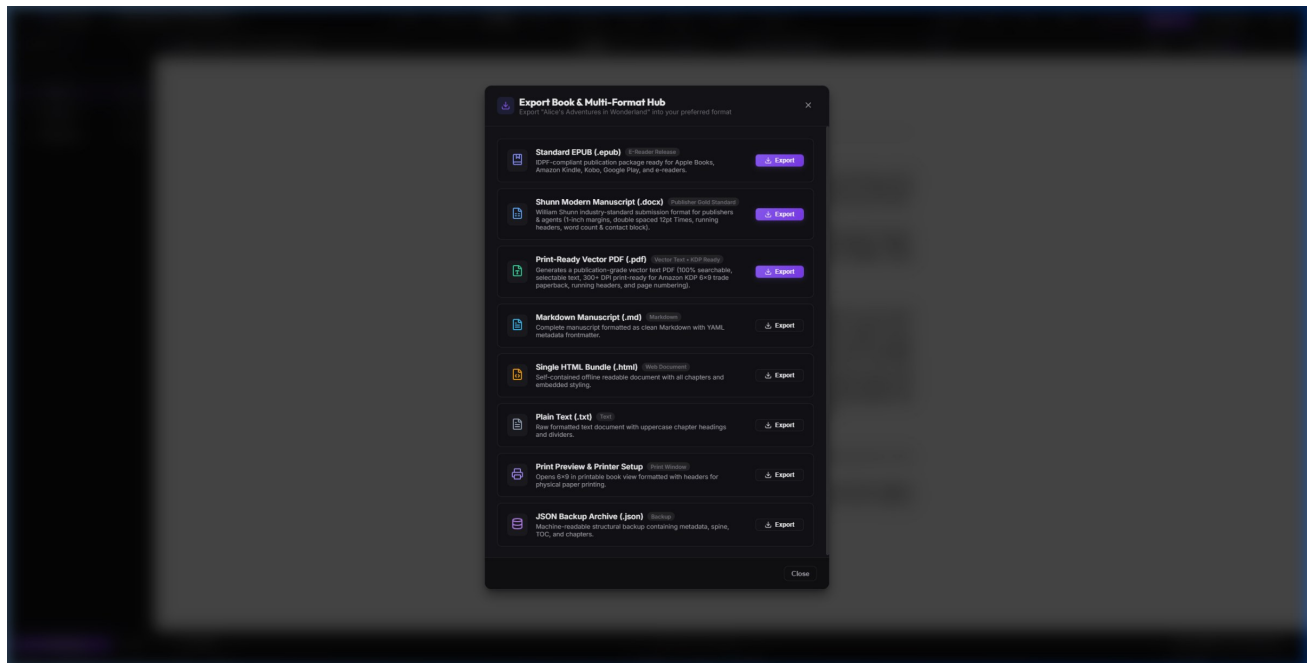


Figure 9.1: The Export Hub dialog with one-click publication targets for PDF, EPUB 3, Shunn DOCX, and Project Backups.

- **Print PDF Typesetter:** Formatted for physical print-on-demand (6x9, 5.5x8.5, A5). Features automated mirror margins, running headers, Roman numeral front matter, and scaled drop caps.
- **Standard EPUB 3:** Verified, reflowable EPUB 3 ebooks passing EpubCheck validation for Amazon Kindle, Apple Books, and Kobo.
- **William Shunn DOCX:** Submission-ready Word document adhering strictly to the industry-standard William Shunn manuscript guidelines required by literary agents and traditional publishers.
- **Chronicle Project (.chronicle):** Comprehensive portable ZIP package containing all drafts, codex dossiers, timelines, covers, and author comments.

Zero-Leakage Export Guarantee: All author review comments, editorial notes, and temporary highlights are automatically stripped during publication exports, guaranteeing that your published PDF, EPUB, or DOCX files are pristine.

Keyboard Shortcuts & Power-User Workflows